Evidence vs. Hypothesis

Keep what you know separate from what you believe may be true.

Product teams need hypotheses to move forward, but problems arise when assumptions are presented as established facts. MVPCompanion makes the status of statements visible so teams can decide what to trust, what to test and what remains unknown.

Four useful labels

E · EVIDENCE

Information actually supplied or observed, such as research notes, usage data or a documented constraint. Evidence can still be incomplete or biased.

H · HYPOTHESIS

A plausible claim or assumption that has not yet been sufficiently supported. It should be possible to investigate or challenge it.

D · DERIVED

An implication logically drawn from stated information. It depends on the accuracy and scope of its source statements.

O · OPEN QUESTION

Something important that is unknown, unresolved or underspecified and needs clarification or investigation.

The central idea

These labels do not rank statements by importance. They show their status. A hypothesis can be strategically important, and evidence can be weak or narrow. Keep the source, context and limitations visible.

Do not overclaim

A confident statement is not automatically evidence. A plausible inference is not the same as an observed fact.

How to classify statements

Use the label that reflects what the material supports—not how certain or persuasive a sentence sounds.

E · EVIDENCE

“In five recorded interviews, three participants said they currently compare book recommendations across several sites.” This is evidence of what those participants reported, not proof about all readers.

H · HYPOTHESIS

“Readers will return weekly if recommendations reflect their taste.” This is a claim to investigate unless supporting evidence is supplied.

D · DERIVED

“Because the current journey requires comparing several sites, reducing that effort may be worth exploring.” This is an implication, not direct evidence of demand.

O · OPEN QUESTION

“Which reader group experiences this problem most often?” The answer is not yet known from the material provided.

Example caution

The examples are illustrative. Do not reuse the interview count or claims as facts about your own product.

Use labels to guide the next decision

The purpose is not to label every sentence mechanically. Use the labels where uncertainty could materially affect a product decision.

A practical sequence

CAPTURE	Record the claim and where it came from.
LABEL	Mark it E, H, D or O, based on the actual support available.
CHECK	Ask whether the evidence supports the full claim or only a narrower version.
PRIORITIZE	Identify which hypotheses are important enough to test first.
LEARN	Update the label or wording when new evidence changes what is justified.

Good practice

Record evidence with its source and context. Do not convert an assumption into evidence merely because a team agrees with it.

Quick self-check: are we distinguishing evidence?

Use this checklist on a product brief, workshop output or MVP specification.

Self-check

- [ ] Claims are linked to a source or explicitly marked as unsupported.
- [ ] Evidence is not generalized beyond the people, context or data it covers.
- [ ] Hypotheses are written so they can be challenged or investigated.
- [ ] Derived implications are distinguishable from direct observations.
- [ ] Open questions are visible rather than silently filled with guesses.
- [ ] Evidence gaps that affect scope or value are prioritized.
- [ ] New information can lead to revised assumptions or decisions.
- [ ] AI-generated content is not treated as evidence without independent support.

Classify a statement

Statement to assess:

Label (E / H / D / O) and why:

What would strengthen or challenge it?

Takeaway

Make uncertainty visible so the team can choose what to trust, what to test and what to clarify.